The Church's Tests

Obeying the Gospel and the Table

"For this reason also I wrote you: to test you to see if you are obedient in everything."
(2 Corinthians 2:9)

https://TeachTheWord.Church

The Gospel Is Something Obeyed

The bridge from covenant tests to church tests

The New Testament speaks of the gospel not only as believed, but as obeyed:

- *"…those who do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus" (2 Thess 1:8)*
- *"What will be the fate of those disobedient to the gospel of God?" (1 Pet 4:17)*
- *"you obeyed from the heart that pattern of teaching" (Rom 6:17)*

A gospel can be obeyed only because it contains commands. And a command is, by nature, a test — the point where trust in the word must become action.

Paul states it as bluntly as possible → apostolic instruction is designed to test: ***"For this reason also I wrote you: to test you to see if you are obedient in everything."*** **(2 Corinthians 2:9)**

Which closes Romans' loop from Week 1: the whole apostleship exists "to bring about the ***obedience of faith***" (Rom 1:5). So, the church's tests fall into four kinds → which we'll walk today.

ENTRY · RECURRING · CONTINUOUS · PROVIDENTIAL

The Entry Test: Obeying the Gospel

Faith confessed · repentance · baptism

The gospel's commands at the threshold:

- Confess: ***"if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord… you will be saved"*** **(Rom 10:9)**
- Repent:

"God… now commands all people everywhere to repent" **(Acts 17:30)**

- Be baptized:

"Repent, and each one of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ" **(Acts 2:38)**

And here is the revealing text → response to a commanded washing disclosed the whole heart:

"The Pharisees and the experts in religious law rejected God's purpose for themselves, because they had not been baptized by John." **(Luke 7:29–30)**

The common people "acknowledged God's justice" by being baptized; the experts refused → and the refusal WAS the verdict on their posture toward God.

Same shape as Eden, Moriah, the manna: a concrete, seemingly modest act whose acceptance or refusal reveals everything. Paul then plants baptism where the old covenant marker stood:

"In him you were also circumcised… having been buried with him in baptism, in which also you were raised with him through faith." **(Colossians 2:11–12)**

Conversion itself is described as a test passed: ***"you obeyed from the heart that pattern of teaching"*** **(Rom 6:17)** → belief that became obedient action.

The Recurring Test: The Table

The covenant meal asks the covenant question → weekly

The Mosaic covenant scheduled its tests (Sabbath, feasts, daily manna). The New Covenant schedules one too → with the examination commanded outright:
"A person should examine himself first, and in this way let him eat the bread and drink of the cup." **(1 Corinthians 11:28)**

The verb is dokimazeto → the assayer's word from Week 5's toolkit. The Lord's Supper is the only ordinance with a STANDING, repeated, commanded self-test attached → and real consequences for taking it carelessly (11:27–30).

Two more recurring obediences whose neglect Scripture treats as revealing:

- The assembly itself → ***"not abandoning our own meetings, as some are in the habit of doing"*** **(Heb 10:25)** *(forsaking it is a symptom, not a scheduling problem)*
- Forgiveness in prayer → which Jesus makes explicitly conditional, and therefore diagnostic:

"For if you forgive others their sins, your heavenly Father will also forgive you. But if you do not forgive others, your Father will not forgive you."
(Matthew 6:14–15)

Every week the covenant meal asks: is the faith you professed at the door still real at the table?

The Continuous, the Providential, the Final

Three more ways faith is proven → and the last exam of all

CONTINUOUS

1 John → "by this we know"

- Moral: keep his commands (2:3)
- Relational: love the brothers (3:14)
- Doctrinal: test the spirits (4:1–3)

PROVIDENTIAL

Trials & wealth

- Suffering proves genuineness (Jas 1:2–3,12; 1 Pet 1:6–7)
- Money is the church's manna: "I am testing the genuineness of your love" (2 Cor 8:8)

FINAL

The last exam

- Examine yourselves now (2 Cor 13:5)
- "Not everyone who says 'Lord, Lord'… but the one who DOES the will" (Matt 7:21–27)

One book is built entirely as a series of tests → 1 John, the "tests of life": do I obey, do I love, do I hold the truth? And the final court is not what we *said* but what we **did with what we believed.**
(Matt 7:24–27 → the two builders; the storm reveals the foundation).

Discussion

Ten minutes → this is the week's practice

1. Of the four → entry, recurring, continuous, providential → which does our congregation talk about least? Why that one?

2. What does weekly self-examination at the table actually involve → practically? What are you examining for?

Berean rule stands: *every claim goes back to the text → eager, and examining.*

Read Like a Berean

For next week → eager, and examining

For next week, read:

- **Romans 12:1–2** → what does Paul ask you to place on the altar? Notice both body AND mind.
- **Malachi 1:6–14** → what was wrong with the priests' offerings? Would you hand it to your governor?

Next week: *The Altar Today → do Christians offer sacrifices? The atonement is finished; so what goes on the altar now?*

This week in one sentence:

The church's faith is tested at the door, at the table, in the life, and through the fire.

"Examine yourselves to see whether you are in the faith."
(2 Corinthians 13:5)

https://TeachTheWord.Church